

Session 2: The Flood Story in the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible is like a family quilt. It is a collection of narratives and poems from all periods of ancient Israelite history that have been curated and assembled into a literary design shape in order to tell a unified story.
- Jesus understood the flood story as a pattern—a theological category to talk about when God overthrows the corrupt power systems of our world.
- The biblical authors designed the stories of Genesis 6-11 to address the main issues of concern at work in the TaNaK, not our modern concerns.

The Hebrew Bible as a Family Quilt



A quilt is made of many preexisting materials, consisting of individual pieces (like the Eden story or the Abraham stories) or sub-collections of pieces (the laws at Mount Sinai, the David stories, or the Psalms) or entire books (like Ruth or Esther). These earlier materials could be incorporated into the collection as they stood or editorially reshaped to fit the new context. But—and this is the key point—it is this new overall context of the final quilt that gives each individual piece its meaning when viewed in light of the whole. Regardless of the meaning of any individual piece outside of or before its incorporation into the quilt, the entire context of the quilt is now the proper frame of reference for understanding every smaller piece.

In the case of Genesis 6-11 (the focus of this class), we must ask ourselves this at every step of our reading: What is the meaning of Genesis 6-11 that is intended by the authors who framed the final shape of the TaNaK, as far as we can discern it? For the authors, Genesis 1-11 formed an introduction to the entire TaNaK, containing the basic themes, vocabulary, and plot elements that would be developed throughout the rest of the collection.

The Many Potential Contexts of the Story of Noah and the Flood

In our modern cultural setting, the Noah story has been made to speak to many topics that the biblical authors did not mean to address. We must be vigilant to distinguish between asking what Genesis 6-11 means within the context of the TaNaK versus what it means for other areas of interest. The difference is one of intention. The biblical authors actually intended the stories to address the main issues of concern at work in the TaNaK, not our modern concerns. Genesis 6-11 may have significance for how we think about other topics in light of the biblical perspective, but we should not mistake this for the meaning of Genesis 6-11 in its native context.

Meaning		Significance		
Genesis 6-11	TaNaK	Introduction to Geology	A Primer on Animal Biology	Ancient Shipbuilding
				
<i>The Meaning Versus Significance of Genesis 6-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>				

Reflection Question

According to Jesus, what is the Hebrew Bible (the Torah, the Prophets, and the Psalms) all about?